prudent just to take what was being served. Then Harvinder, trying to figure out what to add to his soup, ended up adding sugar-free sweetener instead of salt. Bhaji, who always enjoyed a laugh, was aware of what Harvinder had done and kept asking him if he was enjoying his food! Harvinder was too embarrassed to admit his mistake and so he pretended to like it.

Sharjah, in April, was hot, very hot. The heat was oppressive and it was a real test of stamina. I could feel the heat through my shoes and it often caused a burning sensation, which was extremely discomforting. It was physically draining to bat for long hours and, with little recovery time between games, it was a stern test of a player's skill, both physical and mental.

The two matches everyone remembers were both against Australia, on 22 and 24 April 1998. The first one was our last round-robin game, which we needed to win, or score a certain number of runs in, to qualify for the final. Australia had already made it to the final by winning all three of their pool games.

In the first of the two games, Australia batted first and scored a very healthy 284, with 81 from Mark Waugh and a century from Bevan. We needed a good start to get our chase on track. Unfortunately, however, we had lost four wickets for just 138 runs in twenty-nine overs when the match was interrupted. I had never seen a sandstorm in my life. Waves of sand were blowing from one end of the ground to the other and the wind was so strong that I feared my five-foot-five-inch frame would get blown away. The wind was also causing a strange sound and we could only see a few metres ahead of us. Players and umpires were understandably worried about getting sand in their eyes and instinctively dropped to the ground. I quickly went and lay down behind Adam Gilchrist, who I reckoned was strong enough to withstand the force of the wind. My plan was simple – if the wind ever got too strong, I would hold on to Gilchrist for support. While it appears funny in hindsight to have used an Australian wicketkeeper as a shield, the whole experience was rather strange to start with.

Because the match was interrupted for more than forty-five minutes, it was reduced to forty-six overs a side but the target was cut by only eight runs. To win the match, we now needed 138 off seventeen overs, which may appear eminently gettable in this age of Twenty20 cricket but was a really steep target in 1998. A deduction of eight runs for the loss of four